

Brand Communication Through Social Media Influencers: Trust Building and Trust Transfer Mechanisms

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Abstract

By leveraging the trust they have instilled in followers, social media influencers open up new brand communication opportunities. Drawing on interpersonal and brand trust theories, this study conceptualizes influencer trust as a relational, multidimensional concept, and adopts the trust transfer theory to explain how this trust helps with brand communication outcomes. Using a national survey, the study shows that influencer ability, benevolence, integrity, authenticity, interactivity, relatability, and past experience quality contribute to trust in influencer, which then contributes to brand trust and consequently purchase and word-of-mouth intentions. Influencer-brand congruence also plays a moderating role in the model. Relatability and interactivity consistently contribute to all dimensions of trust (i.e., cognitive, affective, and behavioral trust), while other factors only predict certain dimensions. All trust dimensions could transfer from influencers to brands, with cognitive and behavioral trust being the most transferable. The moderating role of influencer-brand congruence only applies to cognitive trust.

Keywords

social media influencers, trust transfer, brand trust, brand-consumer relationship

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Social media influencers have become an essential and effective channel for corporates to connect and communicate with consumers. Their considerable impact on consumer attention, engagement, and purchase decisions (IZEA, 2022) has called for a more thorough understanding of consumer responses to brand communication through influencers. With more brands seeking long-term partnerships with influencers and followers viewing influencers as not only information sources but also (parasocial) relationship partners (Caruelle, 2023), researchers start to consider brand communication through influencers as practices of “multi-layered relationship marketing involving influencer-consumer, influencer-brand, and brand-consumer relationships” (D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021, p. 223). Specifically, influencers work as effective intermediaries who help to connect brands with consumers by leveraging the trusting relationship they have developed with the latter (D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021). A recent report found that influencers were trusted more than celebrities among consumers from all age groups (IZEA, 2022). Trust, a fundamental framework to evaluate influencer-consumer relationship (Ki et al., 2023) and an essential concept in brand-consumer relationship (Lau & Lee, 1999), is therefore a vital element to exploit in this context.

Notwithstanding the importance of the concept, influencer trust is yet to be conceptually refined and empirically examined. Although prior studies have touched on trustworthiness as a dimension of perceived influencer credibility (Breves et al., 2019), the concept has not been thoroughly explored from a relational perspective. In addition, prior studies rarely investigated how influencer trust would contribute to relational brand outcomes (e.g., brand trust) given their overemphasis on transactional outcomes (e.g., purchase intention). As scholars began to realize the critical role of trust in influencer communication (Ki et al., 2023; D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021), the development of influencer trust and its brand communication implications need to be further clarified.

To fill the research gaps, this study drew on interpersonal and brand trust theories and conceptualized influencer trust as a relational concept with cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions. This study then tested a mediated model that placed this multidimensional, relational trust at the heart. With the premise that influencers have an impact on brand communication outcomes because they are trusted by consumers and this trust could transfer from influencers to the associated brands, this study aimed at investigating influencer-related factors that foster consumers’ trust in influencers, the brand outcomes of this trust, and the possible moderators. More importantly, to better comprehend the multidimensional concept of influencer trust, the study further explored the determinants and outcomes of its different dimensions. As such, the study adds to the literature of brand communication by offering a more nuanced view that focuses on how influencer-follower relationship contributes to consumer-brand relationship.

The Concept of Trust and the Trust Transfer Theory

In interpersonal relationship literature, trust is well recognized as a multifactorial concept that consists of three interrelated subfactors: cognition, affect, and behavioral

intention (Colquitt et al., 2007; Lewicki et al., 2006). According to Lewicki et al. (2006), the cognitive subfactor addresses “the beliefs and judgments about another’s trustworthiness” (p. 997). It is often described as the trustor’s confident expectation that the trustee will not let the trustor down in terms of performance. The affective subfactor encompasses the emotional bond and care between the trustor and the trustee. The behavioral-intention subfactor involves the trustor’s willingness to act on the trustee’s words and actions and to accept vulnerability (Lewicki et al., 2006). Following such a conceptualization, this study defines influencer trust as consumers’ confident expectation of an influencer’s performance (cognitive trust), emotional bonding with the influencer (affective trust), and willingness to depend on the influencer’s recommendation for purchase decisions (behavioral trust).

The trust transfer theory suggests that trust is transferrable between a trusted source and a related entity (Stewart, 2003). The transfer takes place “when a person (the trustor) bases initial trust in an entity (a person, group, or organization referred to as the target) on trust in some other related entity, or on a context other than the one in which the target is encountered (e.g., a different place)” (Stewart, 2003, p. 6). Trust transfer operates via either a cognitive process, where mere knowledge of the source-target relationship impacts information processing and impression formation, or a communication process, where both the source and the target directly influence the trustor (Stewart, 2003). Previous work suggests that all the cognitive, affective, and behavioral aspects of influencer trust may transfer to the recommended brand through the two processes.

First, the cognitive process of trust transfer is based on the notion of entitativity that refers to the degree to which an aggregate of individuals is considered to be a real group—a cohesive unit (D. T. Campbell, 1958). If two entities are perceived as belonging to a cohesive unit, people tend to assume some extent of consistency between them, and are therefore likely to form impression of the target entity according to the already formed impression of the source entity; new information about the target entity will also be gathered, processed, and interpreted in a way that confirms the impression (Stewart, 2003). Through this process, the cognitive aspect of trust may transfer, such that the perceived trustworthiness of an influencer results in the perceived trustworthiness of a partner brand.

Second, the communication process in which an influencer co-presents with a brand in posts and recommends it to followers creates additional opportunities for the transfer of affective and behavioral trust. Concerning affective trust, both the affect transfer theory of advertising that is rooted in classical conditioning (Gorn, 1982) and the attachment transfer theory of influencer marketing that derives from the human brand theory (Ki et al., 2020) support an automatic transfer of positive feelings and emotions from an influencer to a paired brand, considering the two entities as either an unconditional vs. a conditional stimulus, or a human brand vs. its branded extension. Concerning behavioral trust, the communication process allows influencers to reinforce followers’ behavioral dependency on them for quick purchase decisions by accentuating how much they like the brand and explicitly inviting followers to try it. Recommendations from a trusted source can prompt consumers to “just buy it” without “think[ing] for a

bit” (Cao et al., 2021, p. 14). As such, the cognitive, affective, and behavioral aspects of influencer trust help to build brand trust and affect consumer behaviors.

Research Model and Hypothesis Development

Antecedents of Trust in Influencer

This study focuses on influencer-related factors as perceived by followers. A review of the literature on interpersonal and influencer trust suggested seven major factors, namely ability, benevolence, integrity, authenticity, relatability, interactivity, and past experience quality.

Ability, Benevolence, and Integrity. These three factors are the most acknowledged and investigated antecedents of trust in the literature on interpersonal trust. According to Mayer et al. (1995), ability refers to the trustee’s skills and competencies to exert influence within a domain. Benevolence refers to the trustee’s willingness to do good to the trustor. Integrity refers to whether the trustee adheres to principles considered acceptable by the trustor (Mayer et al., 1995). All of the three attributes have been found impactful on trust building in diversified contexts (Colquitt et al., 2007; Lewicki et al., 2006). It is reasonable that these factors would also contribute to influencer trust.

Authenticity and Relatability. Research on influencer trust specifically underscored authenticity and relatability (Audrezet et al., 2020; D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021; Marôpo et al., 2020; Martensen et al., 2018). Perceived authenticity refers to the perception that a person “behaves according to his or her true self” (Moulard et al., 2015, p. 173). In the influencer context, cues relied upon by consumers to evaluate influencers’ authenticity include (perceived) intrinsic motivation to create content, passion for one’s field, willingness to present the true self instead of an ideal self, honesty when reviewing products, and transparency about brand partnerships (Audrezet et al., 2020).

Relatability, sometimes referred to as homophily, similarity, or identification, is the extent to which influencers are perceived as relatable, which occurs when followers see a mutual understanding between them and the influencers, based on the similarities and commonalities they share (Marôpo et al., 2020; Martensen et al., 2018). These similarities and commonalities could be either tangible or intangible, including demographic background, physical appearances, life experiences, goals and values, and so on (Marôpo et al., 2020). In the context of influencers, relatability also has a connotation of ordinariness (Marôpo et al., 2020; Martensen et al., 2018). Influencers are perceived as relatable when they make followers feel that they are just normal people regardless of their celebrity-like status (Martensen et al., 2018).

The contribution of authenticity and relatability to influencer trust has been attributed to the social exchange theory, especially the reciprocity principle (Blau, 1964). Social media seem to be ideal platforms for social exchange because they allow relatively low costs of maintaining social relations, compared to offline conditions (Surma, 2016). On social media, people use various resources (e.g., knowledge and enjoyable

persona) in exchange for expected benefits (e.g., recognition and social support), forming reciprocal exchange relations (Urbonavicius et al., 2021). Influencers invest resources in relationships with followers by offering knowledge, inspiration, entertaining content, and attractive characteristics, and followers reciprocate with engagement activities including liking, commenting, forwarding, and subscribing (D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021), which help influencers grow the community and exert influence over social media users (Caruelle, 2023). Such satisfactory exchanges of social resources between the two parties will lead to positive relationship outcomes including trust (D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021). In other words, to win followers' trust, influencers need to show qualities that can function as intangible social exchange resources, such as authenticity and relatability, to facilitate successful social exchanges (D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021).

Interactivity and Past Experience Quality. Trust is a relationship dimension built upon repeated interactions over time (Rempel et al., 1985). This study thus concerns two factors addressing the depth and quality of interactions between influencers and followers, namely interactivity and past experience quality. In computer-mediated, user-to-user communication environments, the depth of interactions can be operationalized as the perceived interactivity of the communicator. Following McMillan (2006), this study defines interactivity as followers' perceptions of influencers' willingness and ability to facilitate two-way or multidirectional communication and empower followers in communication practices (e.g., creating or altering content according to followers' input). The positive effect of interactivity on trust is underpinned by the social presence theory (Short et al., 1976), which implies that interactivity of a communicator would affect the extent to which they are considered a real, sociable person in computer-mediated communications, which then positively influences a receiver's trust in the communicator (Gefen & Straub, 2004).

The other factor, past experience quality, addresses the quality of influencer-follower interactions. Past experience is critical in trust development, as trust develops following a three-stage sequence moving from assessment of the trustee's recurrent behaviors, to conclusions about the trustee's stable dispositions based on past interactions, and ultimately to confidence that the trustee will behave consistently in the uncertain future (Rempel et al., 1985). Trust can also deteriorate or fluctuate over time as negative experiences accumulate (Lewicki et al., 2006). As such, the experiences an influencer offered to a follower are likely to affect the latter's current level of trust in the former.

H1. Ability, benevolence, integrity, authenticity, relatability, interactivity, and quality of past experience with regard to an influencer are positively related to followers' trust in the influencer.

Outcomes of Trust in Influencer: Brand Trust, Purchase Intention, and WOM Intention

As stated earlier, the trust transfer theory suggests that trust in individuals can transfer to associated brands, a phenomenon evidenced by prior studies (M. Kim & Kim,

2023). When trust is developed, it is able to affect behavioral intentions because it decreases perceived risk and encourages risk-taking due to the trustor's confident expectations and positive feelings about the trustee (Lewicki et al., 2006). Previous studies have documented a consistently positive effect of peer trust and brand trust on purchase intention and WOM intention (Cheng et al., 2019; M. Kim & Kim, 2023).

H2: Influencer trust is positively associated with brand trust, which is then positively associated with purchase intention and WOM intention.

Moderator: Influencer-Brand Congruence

Congruence refers to the consistency between relevant characteristics of the spokesperson and relevant attributes of the brand (Misra & Beatty, 1990). Studies have explored multiple aspects of influencer-brand congruence, including expertise domain, personality, and image (Breves et al., 2019; C. Campbell & Farrell, 2020). From the trust transfer perspective, influencer-brand congruence could moderate the transfer of trust from influencers to brands by affecting the perceived relatedness between them (Stewart, 2003). This is consistent with the match-up hypothesis in celebrity endorsement, which claims that the endorser-brand congruence substantially affects consumers' attitudes and behaviors with regard to the endorsed brand (Till & Busler, 2000). When an influencer recommends a congruent brand, followers are likely to perceive them as closely related and belonging to a cohesive unit, resulting in a greater trust transfer effect and stronger behavioral intentions, and vice versa.

Interested in relational trust that is more long-term, this study focuses on how followers' more stable, accumulated trust in an influencer, which is built over time, would transfer to an associated brand in a given situation. This study thus conceptualizes influencer-brand congruence, a situational factor, as moderating the trust transfer process in the situation, instead of moderating the linkages between influencer characteristics and influencer trust.

H3: Influencer-brand congruence moderates the effect of trust in influencer on brand trust, purchase intention, and WOM intention. The higher the congruence level, the stronger the effects.

Exploratory Analysis: Diving Deep into Trust in Influencers

Researchers have been interested in comparing the different bases of trust and learning their respective characteristics. For example, Lewicki et al. (2006) and Colquitt et al. (2007) disagreed on the types of trust to which ability, benevolence, and integrity contribute. Although not distinguishing between trust dimensions, D. Y. Kim and Kim's (2021) conceptualization of relatability (termed homophily in their study) and authenticity also suggested the possibility of the two characteristics contributing to different components of trust. While cognitive and affective trust have been examined repeatedly, behavioral trust is hardly studied collectively. To better understand the

multidimensional concept of influencer trust, this study investigates whether differences exist among the components in terms of determinants and outcomes.

RQ1. How do the influencer-related factors contribute to cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions of influencer trust respectively?

RQ2. How do cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions of influencer trust contribute to brand trust, purchase intention, and WOM intention respectively?

Method

Employing a national survey, this study gathered data from consumers following influencers across various platforms to maximize generalizability.

Sampling

The main test included 1,033 participants from Qualtrics' national panels, using age and gender quotas based on prior reports (NapoleonCat, 2020; ThinkNow, 2019). The sample was gender-balanced (49.4% being male, 50.1% being female, and .5% being other genders) with a focus on the young demographic (60% were 18–34 years old, 30% were 35–54 years old, and 10% were above 55 years old). Demographic characteristics of the sample can be found in the Appendix.

Procedures

The participants were screened using two conditions: they had to (1) follow at least one influencer on any social media platform, and (2) recall having seen the influencer(s) recommending one or more brands in a recent post. The definition adapted from Mediakix (2020) was presented first to frame the context: "Social media influencers are personalities who create and publish content regularly on social media and have attracted more than 1,000 followers. They are different from traditional celebrities as they became famous primarily because of their work on social media. They might be active on Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, Facebook, Twitter, blogs, or other platforms." After giving consent, participants were asked to recall an influencer they follow who has recommended brands and write down the influencer's name or social media handle. Next, they answered a series of questions regarding the influencer, including influencer trust and the speculated antecedents. In the following phase, participants were instructed to recall a brand that the influencer recommended recently. To help them recall, the participants were requested to briefly describe the brand (e.g., brand name or product category). Questions regarding the brand, including influencer-brand congruence, brand trust, purchase intention, and WOM intention were then presented.

Measures

All scales were adapted from previous studies. The survey used 5-point Likert and semantic differential scales to collect data (see Table 1 for scale items).

Table 1. Scale Items, Sources, and Properties.

Factor	SL	α	CR	AVE	M	SD
ABL: Ability (Mayer & Davis, 1999)						
They have much knowledge about the topics they discuss.	0.84	.92	.92	.73	4.15	.91
I feel very confident about their skills and expertise.	0.88					
They have specialized capabilities that can add value to the online social community that they are in.	0.79					
They are well qualified.	0.91					
BEN: Benevolence (Mayer & Davis, 1999)						
They are very concerned with my welfare.	0.88	.93	.93	.81	3.25	1.24
My needs and desires are very important to them.	0.90					
They really look out for what is important to me.	0.91					
ING: Integrity (Mayer & Davis, 1999)						
They have a strong sense of justice.	0.78	.90	.90	.65	3.97	.88
I never have to wonder whether they will stick to their words.	0.73					
They try hard to be fair in dealing with others.	0.80					
I like their values.	0.87					
Sound principles seem to guide their behavior.	0.85					
AUT: Authenticity (Moulard et al., 2015)						
From your perspective, this influencer is . . .						
Not genuine/Genuine	0.90	.91	.91	.77	4.50	.74
Fake/real	0.88					
Inauthentic/authentic	0.85					
REL: Relatability (Auer & Palmgreen, 2000)						
They remind me of myself.	0.74	.88	.88	.66	3.57	1.03
I can identify with them.	0.79					
They were like my friends.	.079					
They seem to understand me.	0.91					
INT: Interactivity (Wu & Chang, 2005)						
They take great pleasure to answer followers' questions.	0.78	.84	.84	.64	4.08	.82
They take great pleasure to address followers' needs.	0.83					
They want to listen to their followers.	0.79					
PEQ: Past experience quality (Huang & Hsu, 2009)						
Negative/positive	0.91	.93	.93	.76	3.72	.99
Unfavorable/favorable	0.85					
Dissatisfied/satisfied	0.88					
Not pleased/pleased	0.84					

(continued)

Table 1. (continued)

Factor	SL	α	CR	AVE	M	SD
CTI: Cognitive trust in influencer (McAllister, 1995)						
They create content with professionalism and dedication.	0.80	.88	.88	.71	4.16	.92
Given their track record, I see no reason to doubt their competence.	0.83					
They can be counted on to give me good advice.	0.89					
ATI: Affective trust in influencer (McAllister, 1995; Yang et al., 2009)						
I can talk about difficulties I am having in life and they will listen.	0.82	.90	.89	.68	3.35	1.14
They and I can both freely share ideas, feelings, and hopes.	0.78					
Both they and I have made considerable emotional investments in our relationship.	0.83					
I feel secure with them because of their sincerity.	0.87					
BTI: Behavioral trust in influencer (Gillespie, 2011)						
How willing are you to . . .						
Rely on their judgments about products/services.	0.81	.90	.90	.70	3.89	.91
Depend on them to decide what to buy.	0.81					
Rely on their skills and abilities regarding products/services.	0.87					
Depend on them to choose products/services for you.	0.84					
BT: Brand trust (Lau & Lee, 1999)						
This brand can be counted on to do its job.	0.92	.94	.94	.78	4.06	.92
I trust this brand.	0.85					
I feel I can trust this brand completely.	0.88					
I feel secure buying this brand because I know that it will not let me down.	0.88					
IBC: Influencer-brand congruence (Schaefer & Keillor, 1997)						
Their image and the image of the brand are well-matched.	0.78	.84	.84	.57	4.20	.75
They probably use this brand of product in their everyday life.	0.72					
They possess expertise relevant to this brand.	0.80					
They are logically related to the brand.	0.73					
PI: Purchase intention (Kraft et al., 2005)						
After seeing the influencer post. . .						
I considered buying the product/service.	0.89	.93	.93	.82	3.88	1.13
I intended to buy the product/service.	0.92					
I planned to buy the product/service.	0.91					

(continued)

Table 1. (continued)

Factor	SL	α	CR	AVE	M	SD
WI: WOM intention (Shi & Chow, 2015)						
If someone else seeks your advice on what to buy and the product/service recommended by the influencer is still available. . .						
I would recommend this product/service to them.	0.93	.91	.91	.77	4.09	.97
I would pass on information about this product/service I get from the influencer to them.	0.82					
I would introduce this product/service to them.	0.87					

Note. SL = standardized loading; α = Cronbach's α ; CR = composite reliability; AVE = average variance extracted; M = mean; SD = standard deviation.

Data Analysis

The partial least square approach of structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) was chosen over the covariance-based approach (CB-SEM) to analyze the data given its ability to handle both reflective and formative factors, advantages in testing interaction effects, robustness to violations of multivariate normality, and popularity in the business research area (Lowry & Gaskin, 2014). The software SmartPLS and SPSS were used. Data screening showed that the data were normally distributed without extreme outliers or multicollinearity issues. Then the measurement model was assessed in the following three steps.

Reflective Constructs. All constructs in the model, except trust in influencer, are reflective. After evaluating item loadings, one item regarding interactivity was dropped due to low loading. All constructs then exhibited good reliability and validity according to Hair et al (2010): item loadings ≥ 0.70 , composite reliability (CR) $\geq .70$, Cronbach's $\alpha \geq .70$, average variance extracted (AVE) $\geq .50$ (see Table 1 for details), and the square root of AVE of a construct was larger than the absolute values of its correlations with other constructs (see Table 2).

The Formative Construct. The second-order construct, trust in influencer, was conceptualized as a formative construct built upon three bases of trust: cognitive, affective, and behavioral trust. The weights of the three trust components on trust in influencer were all significant, suggesting adequate convergent validity. Multicollinearity was not problematic, with variance inflation factors (VIF) ranging from 1.66 to 1.89. As such, the second-order formative construct—trust in influencer—exhibited good reliability and validity. Because trust in influencer was endogenous here, latent factor scores were obtained following the two-step approach (Lowry & Gaskin, 2014) and used for subsequent analyses involving this second-order construct.

Test for Common Method Bias. Because both exogenous variables and endogenous variables were collected at a single point of time using one questionnaire, a Harman's

Table 2. The Fornell-Larcker Test Results.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
1	ABL	.86												
2	BEN	.57	.90											
3	ING	.78	.67	.81										
4	AUT	.47	.49	.59	.88									
5	REL	.57	.72	.72	.54	.81								
6	INT	.44	.58	.55	.61	.61	.80							
8	PEQ	.45	.43	.54	.78	.61	.87							
9	CTI	.77	.58	.80	.60	.59	.59	.84						
10	ATI	.46	.74	.61	.48	.60	.46	.62	.82					
11	BTI	.49	.50	.49	.51	.55	.52	.58	.55	.83				
12	BT	.43	.40	.41	.46	.58	.47	.50	.39	.57	.76			
13	IBC	.52	.47	.58	.45	.55	.45	.61	.55	.65	.59	.88		
14	PI	.42	.46	.42	.35	.39	.33	.48	.53	.62	.48	.72	.91	
15	WI	.50	.44	.50	.44	.40	.40	.59	.50	.68	.56	.80	.77	.88

Note. Bold values on the diagonal are the square root of AVE of the constructs. Off diagonal are the correlations between the constructs.

one-factor test was performed to assess the possible impact of common method bias. An exploratory, unrotated factor analysis showed that no single factor explained the majority of the variance in the model, suggesting the minimal impact of common method bias.

Results

In total, the model accounted for 70% of the variance in trust in influencer, 49% in brand trust, 50% in purchase intention, and 59% in WOM intention, indicating satisfactory explanatory power. The model also showed a good fit, NFI=0.96, SRMR=0.03. Note that PLS-SEM focuses on testing the relationship between drivers and target constructs rather than the overall model fit, thus offering limited model fit information.

Hypothesis Testing

As shown in Figure 1, all predictors were positively and significantly related to trust in influencer. Relatability turned out to be the strongest predictor ($\beta = .27, p < .001, f^2 = 0.11$), followed by ability ($\beta = .18, p < .001, f^2 = 0.05$), benevolence ($\beta = .18, p < .001, f^2 = 0.05$), interactivity ($\beta = .16, p < .001, f^2 = 0.05$), integrity ($\beta = .10, p < .01, f^2 = 0.01$), past experience ($\beta = .10, p < .01, f^2 = 0.01$), and authenticity ($\beta = .08, p < .05, f^2 = 0.01$). As such, H1 was supported, though the effect sizes of the predictors were small.

H2 addressed the mediation role of brand trust. Trust in influencer was positively related to brand trust ($\beta = .54, p < .001, f^2 = 0.43$), purchase intention ($\beta = .27, p < .001, f^2 = 0.07$), and WOM intention ($\beta = .25, p < .001, f^2 = 0.08$). Brand trust was also positively related to purchase intention ($\beta = .46, p < .001, f^2 = 0.21$) and WOM intention ($\beta = .52, p < .001, f^2 = 0.34$). Concerning the mediation effects, brand trust partially mediated the correlations between influencer trust and the two behavioral intentions. H2 was thus supported with the paths presenting small to medium effects.

As for H3, the moderation effect, influencer-brand congruence moderated the association between trust in influencer and brand trust by strengthening their positive correlation ($\beta = .07, p < .05$). As such, H3 was partially supported.

Exploratory Analysis

To answer the two RQs, the second-order trust concept was removed from the model and cognitive trust, affective trust, and behavioral trust functioned as three parallel mediators. For exploratory purposes, the moderator influencer-brand congruence was posed to moderate each of the paths from a trust component to brand trust, purchase intention, or WOM intention. To pursue the best accuracy, the exploratory analysis used the full measurement model instead of latent factor scores, since there was no longer a second-order endogenous variable to address.¹ The results are presented in Table 3.

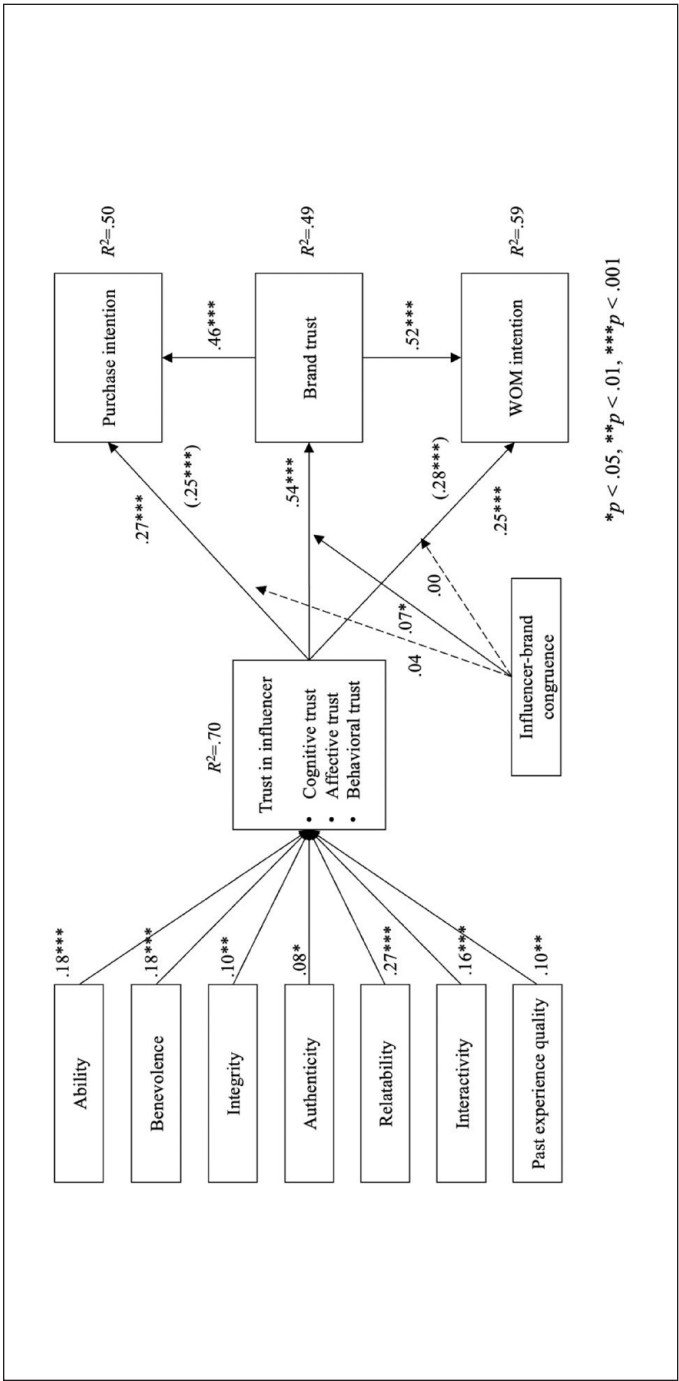


Figure 1. Structural model results regarding overall influencer trust.
 Note. Insignificant paths are indicated by dotted lines. Statistics between parentheses are standardized indirect effects.

Table 3. Structural Model Results Regarding Trust in Influencer Dimensions.

CTI	ATI		BTI		BT		PI		WI	
	β	f^2	β	f^2	β	f^2	B	f^2	β	f^2
ABI	.38***	0.23	-.09	0.01	/	0.04	/	/	/	/
BEN	-.10*	0.02	.39**	0.18	/	0.01	/	/	/	/
ING	.30**	0.09	.06	0.00	/	0.01	/	/	/	/
AUT	.06	0.01	.01	0.00	/	0.01	/	/	/	/
REL	.17**	0.04	.42***	0.18	/	0.03	/	/	/	/
INT	.12**	0.03	.13**	0.02	/	0.04	/	/	/	/
PEQ	.09	0.01	.01	0.00	/	0.01	/	/	/	/
CTI	/	/	/	/	.29***	0.10	-0.08 (0.15***)	0.01	.12* (.15***)	0.02
ATI	/	/	/	/	.15***	0.03	0.16*** (0.08***)	0.03	.00 (.08***)	0.00
BTI	/	/	/	/	.28***	0.10	0.24*** (0.15***)	0.06	.25*** (.15***)	0.09
BT	/	/	/	/	/	/	0.52***	0.25	.53***	0.39
R ²	.75		.67		.60		0.58		.70	

Note. Statistics between parentheses are standardized indirect effects.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

RQ1 focused on how the factors predicted different facets of trust. Ability ($\beta = .38$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.23$) and integrity ($\beta = .30$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.09$) were the strongest predictors for cognitive trust, while relatability ($\beta = .42$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.18$) and benevolence ($\beta = .39$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.18$) were the strongest for affective trust. Behavioral trust was more evenly predicted by multiple factors, with ability ($\beta = .24$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.04$) being the strongest.

RQ2 addressed the relative contribution of the three trust facets to brand trust, purchase intention, and WOM intention. All of the facets significantly and positively predicted brand trust, with cognitive trust being the strongest ($\beta = .29$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.10$), closely followed by behavioral trust ($\beta = .28$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.10$) and then affective trust ($\beta = .15$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.03$). As for behavioral intention outcomes, behavioral trust became the strongest predictor for both purchase intention ($\beta = .24$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.06$) and WOM intention ($\beta = .25$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.09$). Concerning the moderating role of influencer-brand congruence, high congruence was able to boost the positive effects of cognitive influencer trust on brand trust ($\beta = .23$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = 0.09$) and WOM intention ($\beta = .10$, $p < .05$, $f^2 = 0.02$). None of the other moderating effects were significant.

Discussion

Acknowledging the critical role of trust in brand communication through social media influencers, this study examined the conceptual structure as well as antecedents and outcomes of influencer trust in detail. In this section, we first discuss the results in relation to existing knowledge, with a focus on associations that are substantively meaningful, then offer theoretical and practical implications, and finally address limitations and future research directions.

Result Interpretation

H1 concerned predictors of influencer trust. The full support of H1 suggested the unique contribution of each of the predictors. Among the predictors, relatability appeared to be the strongest and the only one that displayed substantive significance, in favor of recent studies on influencers that emphasized relatability (Marôpo et al., 2020; Martensen et al., 2018). Influencers, in essence, are “expert(s) with whom I can identify” (Feng et al., 2021, p. 972). The fact that relatability outperformed more well-established contributors such as ability, integrity, and benevolence, illustrated the necessity to consider contributors unique to the specified trusting context. For example, trust in influencers is likely to differ from that in celebrities, which rarely encompasses relatability (Hussain et al., 2020).

H2 and H3 concerned the trust transfer mechanism in brand communication through influencers. The support of H2 validated the mechanism in explaining the impact of influencers on consumer behaviors. As e-commerce and social media continue to converge, trusted intermediaries like influencers would effectively help brands connect

with and instill trust in the target audience. The partial support of H3 evidenced that high congruence could facilitate the transfer of trust between two entities, in support of previous studies (Stewart, 2003). However, the enhancing effect of congruence did not extend to *behavioral* intentions like purchase or WOM intention. This echoes a previous study on the match-up hypothesis that detected a significant moderating effect of endorser-brand fit on brand attitude but not purchase intention (Till & Busler, 2000). A possible explanation is that the evaluation of congruence is likely to be mostly cognitive (Schaefer & Keillor, 1997), but the impact of influencer trust on consumer behavioral intentions is beyond cognition—the core idea is behavioral dependability without too much thinking. This reasoning was also supported by the exploratory analysis of RQ2 that found behavioral trust the strongest predictor of purchase and WOM intentions among all three trust dimensions, as well as the finding that congruence only facilitated the transfer of cognitive trust.

The findings of RQ1 revealed differences among the three trust facets. The findings supported Colquitt et al.'s (2007) prediction that ability and integrity contribute to cognitive trust while benevolence contributes to affective trust, meanwhile disfavored Lewicki et al.'s (2006) proposition of measuring cognitive trust in terms of the three qualities. The substantively significant contribution of relatability to affective trust validated the notion that relatability can be a source of attractiveness (D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021), which is often associated with affective trust. While cognitive and affective trust were more distinct concepts that relied on their own sources to develop, behavioral trust, the facet that was found to predict brand-related behavioral intentions best in this study, required more diverse sources to build. This provided evidence to the notion that behavioral trust represents a higher level of trust that involves both rationality and affect and is developed through repeated interactions (Lewicki et al., 2006; Rousseau et al., 1998). Yet, the small effect sizes of the predictors signified the difficulty of predicting this subfactor of trust. Altogether, the findings were consistent with the proposition that one may trust and distrust another simultaneously (Lewicki et al., 2006) and moved forward to indicate that this trust and distrust may exist in distinct dimensions.

RQ2 concerned the associations between trust dimensions and brand outcomes. In addition to what has been discussed earlier, the results depicted that all trust components—cognitive, affective, and behavioral—can be transferred. Most studies drawing on the trust transfer theory emphasized the cognitive process of trust transfer and overlooked the communication process (M. Kim & Kim, 2023; Shi & Chow, 2015; Stewart, 2003). The transfer of cognitive trust was thus well documented, but the other two facets needed more research. This study revealed that behavioral trust was equally powerful to cognitive trust in fostering brand trust, and emerged as the strongest predictor of purchase and WOM intentions. A plausible explanation informed by the social exchange model for triads (Rojas et al., 2017) is that dependency of the first agent (e.g., followers) on the intermediary (e.g., influencers), such as indicated by followers' behavioral trust in influencers, is crucial for the transfer of trust to the second agent (e.g., brands). Furthermore,

in the triadic relationship among influencers, followers, and brands, influencer-follower relationship determines followers' willingness to engage with branded content (Caruelle, 2023). Followers might perceive their brand-related attitudes and behaviors as social exchange resources they can utilize to reward influencers. Since influencers rely heavily on brand sponsorship to make profits, responses desired by sponsors (e.g., brand trust, purchase, and WOM) are indeed sought-after rewards. Because trust engenders reciprocity (Lewicki et al., 2006), the more consumers trust an influencer, especially as they accept vulnerability and take risks (i.e., behavioral trust), the more they will reciprocate. The mediation test results delineated the critical role of brand trust in determining consumer decisions as it fully mediated some of the associations. It seems that in some aspects, influencer-follower relationship has to function through building brand trust to affect consumer behaviors. In addition, influencer-brand congruence only exerted an impact on the transfer of cognitive trust, suggesting that it may not be appropriate to consider influencer-brand congruence as a moderator when the predictor variable is less cognitive.

Theoretical and Practical Implications

Overall, this study added to the literature in three aspects. First, it contributed to the literature of brand communication by investigating from a nuanced perspective—trust transfer from intermediaries to brands. The study illustrated the potential strength of the trust transfer framework in understanding consumer responses to influencer marketing. Second, this study deepened our understanding of the concept of trust. The study shed light on the conceptual structure of trust and the differences among its dimensions by exploring the antecedents and outcomes of each dimension. In particular, the study empirically examined variables that had not been sufficiently examined, including the behavioral dimension of trust and antecedents such as relatability. Third, this study contributed to the advancement of the trust transfer theory by incorporating the cognitive-affective-behavioral framework of trust and being one of the first studies testing the transferability of the dimensions.

The study also provided valuable practical implications. The findings suggested that in an age of distrust, brands should choose influencers who have established a professional yet relatable image, who communicate the values they stand by and their goodwill to benefit the followers, who stress their authenticity, and who actively address followers' needs and wants. It is worth noting that while a presentation of the true self might be necessary in attracting and sustaining followership—our respondents reported high levels of perceived authenticity regarding the influencers they recalled—its impact on trust building is limited. To instill trust, the aspects of authenticity that convey good intentionality might be more important (as in D. Y. Kim & Kim, 2021) than the aspects that communicate the true self (as in this study).

In addition, as influencers may have strengths in diverse trust dimensions, brands need to pay attention to not only the overall level but also the composition of trust gained by the influencers. Influencers primarily trusted in dimensions that match brands' campaign goals are desirable. For example, expert-like influencers who are mostly cognitively trusted may best demonstrate products' functional values and foster immediate, initial brand trust. However, they might perform less desirably in creating emotional connections or stimulating WOM spreading. Moreover, brands could focus on highlighting particular influencer characteristics in campaigns to leverage a certain type of trust. For instance, when the communication objective is to enhance consumers' affective trust in the brand, the brand could have influencers communicate how they relate to followers on the one hand and how they identify with the lifestyles and values the brand represents on the other hand to make a connection. An expression of benevolence would also help. When the objective is to increase cognitive trust, brands should choose influencers who are highly congruent with the brands and showcase their expertise and integrity in the content.

Limitations and Future Research

The current study has several limitations. First, because this study employed the survey methodology, the results were subject to recall biases and self-report errors. For example, the respondents were likely to recall influencers they liked most or might have mistakenly reported their purchase intentions. Future researchers could intentionally involve influencers that consumers follow but like less and use actual behavioral data to assess the variables. On a related note, since the cross-sectional survey design did not imply causality, the results only suggested associations between concepts, not causal relations. Although causes and effects were speculated, they were subject to reverse causality. Second, past experience was only measured in terms of valence; other experience attributes such as length and interaction frequency could offer additional insight. It would be insightful to study these attributes given the importance of past experiences on trust development and involvement. Third, adopting the trust transfer theory and focusing on influencer-related factors, this study only examined the moderating role of influencer-brand congruence. There could be several other moderators, such as advertising disclosure, brand familiarity, and influencer type. There could also be more variables affecting influencer trust. Future researchers could introduce different factors and moderators to the model and examine their roles.

Appendix. Demographic Characteristics of the Sample.

Characteristic	Statistics
Age	18–34 years old: 60% 35–54 years old: 30% 55+ years old: 10% $M = 34.92$, $SD = 12.06$
Gender	Male: 49.4% Female: 50.1% Other genders: .5%
Race	White: 72.7% Black or African American: 13.8% Asian: 5.8% American Indian or Alaska Native: 1.7% Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander: .4% Other races: 2.5% Biracial/multiracial: 3.1%
Hispanic origin	16.8%
Income	Lower than \$40,000: 34.2% \$40,000–\$69,999: 22.9% \$70,000–\$99,999: 16.4% Above \$100,000: 26.5%
Education	High school or less than high school: 19.1% Some college but no degree: 21.9% Associate or bachelor's degree: 38.9% Master's, doctoral, or professional degree: 20.1%

Author Note

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Note

1. As a result, in this analysis the path coefficients from brand trust to the two behavioral intention outcomes, purchase intention and WOM intention, were slightly different from those in the first analysis that used latent factor scores.

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